Human-made Things in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: The Works of Their Hands: Man-made Things in the Bible, by Ray Pritz © 2009 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Sandal, shoe

6.13 Sandal, shoe

References:

Hebrew נַעַל, נעל (naʿal) GEN 14:23, EXO 3:5, EXO 12:11, DEU 25:9, DEU 25:10, DEU 29:4, JOS 5:15, JOS 9:5, JOS 9:13, RUT 4:7, RUT 4:8, 1KI 2:5, 2CH 28:15, PSA 60:10, PSA 108:10, SNG 7:2, ISA 5:27, ISA 11:15, ISA 20:2, EZK 16:10, EZK 24:17, EZK 24:23, AMO 2:6, AMO 8:6

Greek σανδάλιον (sandalion) MRK 6:9, ACT 12:8, JDT 10:4, JDT 16:9

Greek ὑπόδημα, ὑποδέομαι (hupodēma, hupodeomai (verb)) MAT 3:11, MAT 10:10, MRK 1:7, MRK 6:9, LUK 3:16, LUK 10:4, LUK 15:22, LUK 22:35, JHN 1:27, ACT 12:8, ACT 7:33, ACT 13:25, EPH 6:15, SIR 46:19

Description and usage:

Leather sandals from the northern palace at Masada, 73 CE (Gary Todd, Israel Museum, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)The sandal was a type of footwear consisting of a sole made of leather (or possibly wood) tied to the foot by means of leather thongs or straps, and used as a shoe for walking.

Translation:

Sometimes a term for “sandal” indicates the footwear of particularly poor people or, in some situations, footwear used only for recreation or sport. If this is the case, it will usually be better to use a general designation for footwear which would include sandals.

Leather sandals from the northern palace at Masada, 73 CE (Gary Todd, Israel Museum, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)Sandals were not buckled, as is done with most modern sandals, but rather tied with straps that were wrapped around the ankles. In those passages that speak of putting sandals on or taking them off, translators should choose a word for tying or untying rather than one that indicates the use of a buckle.